



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

The second is based on a different thought experiment.

If we consider trial #801, it will seem to us random which one Veronica chooses. But there is no real difference between the 801st trial and the first one. So no undetermined actions are really under the control of the agent.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined.
 2. If an action is undetermined, then it is random.
 3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are random. (1,2)
 4. No random acts are free.
-

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions.

The control argument

The roll-back

You have the power to roll back history to an earlier moment and then re-start it. Veronica has just decided that she wants to major in Philosophy rather than Accounting, and this decision was undetermined. So you roll back history to a moment just before her decision; this time, Veronica chooses Accounting. You do this 800 times. In 412 of the trials, she chooses Philosophy; in the other 388, she chooses Accounting.

2. If an action is undetermined, then the agent does not control whether it happens.

Does it help if we say that Veronica agrees that action in all 800 trials?

choice principle, and determinism

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1. If Libertarians are right, then, if there

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unleashed.

C. If Libertarianism is true, there are

raindon.(1,2)

4. No irreflexive acts are free.



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2. If an action is

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

for (2), and one for (3).

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

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The master argument against the reality of free will



future is not as it was with the state of the

3. If determined, the only one

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

theorie about the fact that if DNR



varlatatie + the last of the



then DECISION happens. (3)

happened in the distant past.

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

1. No one has any choice about events which

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

then DECISION. (4,5)

about whether @.

of interest.

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

and none has any choice about whether,

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any



